

Skills Summary

Comparing Written Numerals 1 through 10

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — Compare with a symbol (compare-with-symbols)

Rule:

Count up: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10. The numeral you say **later** is the greater one.

$<$ means *is less than* $>$ means *is greater than* $=$ means *is the same as*

The open end of the symbol always faces the greater numeral; the point faces the smaller one.

Example: Write a symbol between 4 and 8.

Step 1. I want to know which numeral is greater, so I count up and listen for which one I say later.

Step 2. Counting up I say 4 first, then 8. So 8 is greater, and the open end faces 8: $4 < 8$

Try it: Write $<$, $>$, or $=$ between 9 and 5.

check: $9 < 5$

Skill 2 — Pick the greater or the smaller (greater-or-less)

Rule:

Greater = the one said later when counting up (farther right on the number line). **Less** = the one said earlier (farther left).

Example: Which is greater, 6 or 9?

Step 1. The question asks for the greater numeral, so I look for the one that comes later when I count.

Step 2. After 6 I keep counting 7, 8, 9, so 9 comes later: $9 > 6$

Try it: Which is less, 3 or 8? Write the smaller numeral first.

check: $8 > 3$

Skill 3 — Put three numerals in order (order-three-numerals)

Rule:

Do not compare all three at once. Find the **least** first and write it down, then find the least of the two that are left. For greatest-to-least, start with the largest instead.

Example: Put 5, 2, 8 in order from least to greatest.

Step 1. Ordering three numerals is easier one step at a time, so I hunt for the smallest one first.

Step 2. Counting up I say 2 first, then 5, then 8: **2, 5, 8**

Try it: Put 7, 10, 4 in order from greatest to least.

check: 10, 7, 4

Skill 4 — Count on first, then compare (count-on-then-compare)

Rule:

When a problem says *count on* or *one more*, finish the counting and write that numeral down **before** you compare. Compare the two finished numerals, never the starting numbers.

Example: Start at 3 and count on 2. Compare your numeral with 6.

Step 1. The comparison is between my finished numeral and six, so I must count on before I choose a symbol.

Step 2. Counting on two from 3: 4, then 5. Now compare 5 with 6 — 5 is said first: $5 < 6$

Try it: Start at 4 and count on 2. Compare your numeral with 10.

check: $10 > 6$

(!) Watch out: A numeral with two digits is not automatically bigger because of its first digit — but 10 *is* greater than every one-digit numeral, because you say it last. And never compare the starting number in a count-on problem; compare the number you land on.
